

Baron Steele hears a light tap on the door to his study. Without waiting, Taevyn gently opens the door a few inches and says through the opening, "Baron, I was sent word that you wished to see me. May I enter?"

"Ah, yes," Steele replied. "Come in, come in, boy."

Steele fights through the sudden shock and pain of seeing the spitting image of his trusted friend and comrade in arms. Does the boy really have to look so much like his father?

"The baroness has called a helpmoot and you will attend as one of my lieutenants," Steele said. "This is an important opportunity for you, boy. I envy you the opportunities you have set before you!"

Steele rarely said the boy's name. It would get caught in his throat ... again, the painful reflection of the friend he had lost. And made all the more painful by the fact that this new version of his old friend seemed not to harbor the affection for Steele that his father had.

"Of course, as Your Grace wishes," Tavern replied. "I am most grateful for the opportunity." Taevyn's voice betrayed a bit more excitement than he intended. Perhaps the Baron will assume its excitement for the job, rather than simply a desire to get away.

"Very good," continued Steele. "... ehr, yes." Steele was caught off guard by the eagerness in the boy's voice, accustomed as he was to receiving an attitude of indifference (if not mild hostility) masked by several layers of courtly mannerisms and formalities. Could this be the moment I've been looking for to give the boy a chance to shine? To prove that he is his father's son and not merely some well-mannered fop?

"Now, boy" Steele leaned over his desk giving Tavern his most serious expression, "You are still green and a helpmoot means there is serious trouble over in Telus Barony. Someone important has..." Steele's face reddens for a brief moment. "Well, there has been blood spilled already, boy, with the likelihood of more to come. I will want you accompanied by someone a bit more ... stalwart. Your fancy sword dancing may be enough to set the hearts of the local lasses aflutter, but in a pitched fight, you'll need more than that, I'd wager. What about that dwarf, newly arrived? I don't know his name, but you know the one I mean. His ill temper makes him something of a liability as a member of my retinue, but for this, he might just be perfect."

Taevyn's eyebrow lifts slightly at the flash of red in the Baron's face. *That's rather out of character. Could it be the rumors about this Laethanderite priestess are true? Well, how very interesting...* Taevyn quickly regains his composure, putting on his practiced face of indifferent loyalty. "The Dwarf?" Tavern asked. "Yes, a rather fiery temper, but I've seen him fight. He's good. Very good, in fact. But, yes, his unpredictability may make him more of a liability than an asset in a coordinated fight. He doesn't exactly fight well with others. Do we know the precise nature of the danger we'll face? The captain may be able to suggest some tactics that take account the Barbarian's unique ... style."

*Fancy sword dancing? Well, at least I can do better than just hack at monsters with a sword, like some second-rate butcher. I'm surprised Nicky isn't more warmed to this Dwarf, it's not as if they are all that different. It's just that the Dwarf doesn't pretend he's other than a barbarian.*

Steele answered matter-of-factly, "I'm afraid all we have at the moment is the suggestion of a Fey curse on House Telus, a plague of monstrous spiders, and reports of people dead, including at least one of name. Don't say anything about this to Tatiana. I was supposed to go riding with her and Marina tomorrow. She will be put out. But there's nothing for it."

"Yes, of course. Tatiana is such a sensitive soul." Taevyn remarked with as much false compassion as he could muster. *A life of comfort and privilege will certainly make one sensitive to the wretched travails of life, like losing a nail or stubbing your toe. We wouldn't want to put out Tatiana by exposing her to reality. Would that she were more like Marina. Marina... Yes, that's an idea.* "Have you discussed the incident with Marina?" Tavern asked. "She's had good battle experience, as you know full well. She would almost certainly prove useful at the Helpmoot. I'll go to her now and invite her..."

"Don't be daft, boy." Steele's sudden outburst surprised even himself, for he had not intended such harshness. "We don't have time to ride down to Longtoothar on the way to Voighton, and Marina is sure to be busy running her men through drills or following up on that Night Swan business for the Count. We must remember: No matter how much we both respect and admire her considerable prowess on the battlefield, that Lt. Mortis no longer reports to me. Count Bartleby is her commanding officer now."

Steele took a moment to feel some relief that the boy looked up to a stolid role model like Marina Mortis. She was like a brother to Steele, as he considered her one of the best warriors he'd ever fought beside (better even than Adella). And she had taken the boy under her wing in those days after his father's death - not surprising since it had been she who introduced the boy's parents to each other all those years ago. Such bittersweet memories.

*A shame that her talents are being squandered by our feckless Count. But that is certainly above my pay grade.*

"Of course, Baron," Tavern replied formally. "I had forgotten. The men do miss her presence." Taevyn hoped the Baron missed the slight crack in his voice. *Marina is what made this place bearable.* Taevyn cleared his throat, "Will that be all? I should hasten to make my preparations for our departure."

"Of course," Steele responded turning his attention back to the sword he had been sharpening. "You are excused. We have much to do if we are to leave within the hour."